CINEMA

Coming of Age

With *Stree 2* and *Vedaa*–both of which released on Independence Day–Abhishek Banerjee is finally getting the meaty roles he feels he deserves



MANDAR DEODHAR

Recently, somebody asked Abhishek Banerjee how it was going being an "outsider" in the film industry. The joke referred to the unending discourse over outsiders struggling in nepotistic Bollywood. "I told him this outsider has two films coming out on Independence Day," Banerjee says with a laugh.

In the horror-comedy sequel *Stree 2*, Banerjee reprises his role as Jana, the protagonist's goofy sidekick. In the action film *Vedaa*, he plays the chief baddie, a gangster-politician in Uttar Pradesh.

For the Kharagpur-born 39-year-old, who had a humble upbringing in Chennai, followed by decades of struggle through theatre and showbiz, playing pivotal roles of such marked variety in two big-ticket theatrical releases is a bewildering new reality.

In the horror-comedy sequel *Stree 2*, Banerjee reprises his role as the protagonist's goofy sidekick. In action film *Vedaa*, he plays the chief baddie

"It still hasn't sunk in," Banerjee says. "Of course, there's a sense of achievement. But I don't know how to react until the box-office results are out." Banerjee can rest easy because *Stree 2* has earned over Rs 500 crore at the global box office, according to the producer's figures, while *Vedaa* has received positive notices.

Banerjee's earliest screen appearance in *Rang De Basanti* (2006) lasted a few seconds, where his character auditions to play Bhagat Singh for the film inside the film and flops. His hustle to get roles in Mumbai led to starting the casting agency Casting Bay, which has handled films like *The Dirty Picture* (2011) and several series, including *Paatal Lok* (2020).

While *Stree* (2018) gave him his first blockbuster, it was his brooding and sinister act in *Paatal Lok* that drew critical acclaim. He has since played comedic roles in *Bala* (2019) and the *Dream Girl* franchise, as well as grimy, villainous roles in the series *Mirzapur* and the 2023 film *Apurva*.

Banerjee's desire to play a charismatic anti-hero like Berlin in the Netflix hit *Money Heist* will be fulfilled in Vipul Shah's upcoming heist film *Hisaab*, where he acts alongside Jaideep Ahlawat and Shefali Shah.

"The method to escape typecasting is that someone will visualise me in a different character from the ones I usually play, and that should become a hit," Banerjee observes. "Because *Stree* was a hit, I got *Dream Girl* and *Bala*. But, if you notice, outside of these films, I have tried to make my mark primarily in drama."

Banerjee also notes his recent shift to mature roles. "It is in *Vedaa* that I have finally played a man," he says. "Until then, I have mostly played boys." What he means is that his roles have usually been of young men, who are the hero's sidekick, or a rowdy employed or led by the primary villain.

Last year's buzzy film festival thriller *Stolen*, where Banerjee played a man wrongly accused of child kidnapping, is an example of him exerting more control in his career. "My mainstream roles being a success can make me afford to do a *Stolen*," he says. ■

–Devarsi Ghosh